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THE HINDU

An exhibit in Chennai displays works of women printmakers who etch memories P2

WHY GOUTAM GHOSE IS RESTORING HIS FILMS P4



PICTURES BY JOHAN SATHYADAS



Chennai's biryani culture comes alive after midnight — from firewood dum in Puliyanthope to smoky plates in Triplicane. Undeterred by the LPG shortage, these kitchens use firewood to serve hundreds of kilos right before the day breaks

The midnight biryani economy

Basheer Bai Biryani

It is midnight when I reach Pudupet. The usually busy road lined with automobile spare-parts and repair shops is shuttered for the night, leaving plenty of space for parking. In the midst of the quiet surroundings brightly lit Basheer Bai Biryani stands out. The frontage is modest and not particularly striking, but once inside, I am greeted by a burst of activity.

Customers pull up on bikes and cycles and head straight to the counter. Inside, a loyal patron, Johnny Bhai, sits waiting patiently for the large vessel to arrive from the kitchen in time for service to begin at midnight. "On most nights I can't pass this place without stopping for their delicious biryani," says Johnny, who runs a business in the neighbourhood.

Shahul Haneeefa, who personally supervises the cooking and daily operations, explains, "Midnight to early morning are our busiest hours. On

Nikhil Raghavan

At 1.30am, Puliyanthope is wide awake. On nights like Eid — and increasingly, well beyond it — ladles clang against aluminium pots, bikes crowd narrow lanes, and the air is scented with firewood and spices.

From Triplicane to Adambakkam, the city's midnight kitchens feed a steady stream of diners. Although a few cooks operate round the clock, many others begin service at midnight and continue until the early hours of the morning.

The LPG shortage, caused by the war in West Asia, has had minimal impact here. While Midnight Bros and Basheer Bai Biryani have traditionally cooked all their biryani on firewood, KGN Aarifa has shifted to firewood. Hotel Bilal Biryani cooks their biryani in a central kitchen away from the city using firewood while their kebabs and tandoori are now being done on coal.

I follow this trail from Adambakkam to Puliyanthope, and from Pudupet to Triplicane, to meet the masters, and understand what keeps the fires burning while the rest of the city sleeps.



weeknights, most of our customers are bachelors living nearby. When we open for lunch, we get many families, and to accommodate them we recently added an air-conditioned dining area on the first floor."

The restaurant was founded in 1990 by Shahul's father, Alikhan Basheer, after whom it is named. "During my father's time we served only during the day and evening, not after midnight," says Shahul. "I introduced the late-night service when I

realised there was a demand for good-quality biryani at those hours."

In the evenings, the menu also includes parotta, chapati and idli, which are popular with a range of non-vegetarian gravies. Mutton biryani is available only on Sundays.

Basheer Bai Biryani is at Adithanar Road, Pudupet, Komaleeswaranpet, Egmore. The chicken biryani costs ₹140 and mutton biryani, ₹260. For more details, call 9840598787.

Midnight Bros Biryani

It is close to midnight as I drive down a still-bustling Mount Road, weaving through endless diversions and barricades as Metro Rail work gathers pace. The city clearly refuses to sleep. And if Chennai stays awake, why should biryani call it a night? My destination is Adambakkam, where Midnight Bros Biryani opens at 10pm and serves customers until 4am, remaining closed only on Sundays.

Tucked away from the busy main road in a quiet residential neighbourhood, Midnight Bros Biryani offers a surprisingly peaceful setting to enjoy a late-night meal. But as the clock moves past midnight, the steady flow of customers suggests that the aroma of freshly cooked biryani is drawing them in.

Akash, brother of proprietor Vijay Arumugam, is at the restaurant, which is set up in a large semi-open space with well-spaced seating. At one end is the kitchen, where the biryani is slow-cooked over firewood. "We first ran an industrial kitchen and later opened the Red Onion restaurant in Ramapuram, which

had to be shut down during the Covid period," says Akash. "After the pandemic, when we decided to start a biryani outlet catering to late-night and early-morning diners, we chose this spacious property and set up Midnight Bros."

Midnight Bros draws both families and younger diners. "The tawa prawns are a particular favourite," says Akash. The outlet sells around 40 kilos of chicken biryani and about 10 kilos of mutton biryani each day. Their customers come from considerable distances, including Sholinganallur, Ambur, Mamallapuram, Poonamallee and Porur.

The enticing aroma is impossible to ignore, and I decide on a quick bite. The mutton pieces are generous and tender, and the rice is fragrant, with a mild smokiness from the firewood, all combining to create a hearty and satisfying meal in the early hours of the morning.

Midnight Bros Biryani is at 4, Dhamodharan Street, Kesari Nagar, Vanuvampet, Adambakkam. A chicken biryani costs ₹150 while mutton biryani is ₹250. For more details, call 9840045309.



KGN Aarifa

Puliyanthope, a bustling neighbourhood awash with bright lights, is dense traffic and a constant flow of people. This is when I join the line at KGN Aarifa, where there is a frenzy of activity around a massive cauldron of biryani. Customers cluster around the counters to collect parcels, while waiters move briskly in and out, serving loaded plates to those seated inside.

Dhanasekar, who is a regular here, says, "I come here several times a week because I can't resist the delicious biryani prepared by Syed Shamsuddin and his son, Syed Moinudeen." Shamsuddin explains that one of their key advantages is the supply of fresh meat from the nearby market every day. The restaurant was launched by their great-grandmother 20 years ago and functions round the clock, with peak business between 130am and 4.30am.

"On weekdays we sell about 500 kilograms of biryani, while on weekends the figure goes up to nearly 1,200 kilograms," says Moinudeen. Most customers come from within a

four-to-five-kilometre radius, though some travel from as far as Madurai and Bengaluru. They receive periodic orders from the Gulf countries and send deep-frozen biryani parcels by air.

"We specialise in dum biryani similar to the Hyderabad style. Our paya biryani is in great demand, and the vadi biryani is another favourite — the rice is partially cooked separately and then layered with a spicy chicken or mutton gravy before being finished on dum," says Shamsuddin, a mutton wholesaler. "While the beef biryani is very popular, our mutton biryani stands out because of the quality of the meat."

I sample a mouthful of fragrant rice with a tender piece of mutton and am impressed by the depth of flavour — clearly the result of years of careful refinement. As I step out, customers continue to pour in, and the staff slip into an even faster rhythm to keep up with the rush.

KGN Aarifa Biryani is at Dr Ambedkar College Road, near Plantop, VOC Nagar, Puliyanthope. A chicken biryani is ₹110 and mutton biryani, ₹300. For more details, call 8072298895.



Hotel Bilal Biryani

Triplicane has traditionally been home to communities for whom biryani forms an essential part of the daily diet, and it is therefore dotted with numerous outlets. My destination is Hotel Bilal Biryani, located at the beginning of Triplicane High Road. The restaurant opens at 6.30pm and continues serving customers until the early hours of the next morning. The frontage is alive with activity — large vessels line the entrance, kebabs sizzle on skewers, and parottas are briskly kneaded and cooked.

Md Irfanullah arrives, accompanied by his energetic father, Md Amanullah. "We started this outlet six years ago during Ramzan," says Irfanullah. "During the Ramzan season we remain open until 5am, while on regular days we usually close around 3am."

The outlet draws customers from far beyond Triplicane. "We get a lot of



patrons from the IT corridor along OMR and from the industrial areas in Sriperumbudur," he explains. "They usually inform us in advance about their requirements, and we keep their orders ready, since the outlet itself does not have much seating space."

"Our speciality is biryani cooked over firewood. The cooking is done in a large kitchen at another location, and vessels of freshly prepared food are brought here at regular intervals," says Irfanullah. He takes particular pride in the eatery's paya and shawarma. A recent milestone for the family has been the launch of their first overseas venture, Sri Lanka Bilal, in Colombo.

To appeal to a younger clientele from the IT sector, Irfanullah has actively embraced social media. I sample a spoonful of the firewood-cooked biryani. The subtle smoky flavour enriches the rice and meat, creating a taste that feels distinct from the more standardised, mass-produced version offered by many well-known brands in the city.

Hotel Bilal Biryani is at Police Station, 1, Triplicane High Road, opposite DI, Police Quarters, Triplicane. Chicken biryani costs ₹120. For more details, call 9962387288.

Inheritance: Memory and Matter, an exhibition at the InKo Centre, brings together women printmakers who etch and emboss memory, tracing legacies across time and material

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There is something at once familiar and deeply powerful about being in a space dominated by women artists. It feels like an unearthing of unspoken voices, of memories and inheritance that have shaped civilisations, histories, and narratives.

In artist Champa Sharath's *Continued Harmony*, one is transported to a *paati's* home; to the stillness of early mornings when she would rise to draw the day's *kolam*.

Champa is among the 10 women artists featured in *Inheritance: Memory and Matter* at the InKo Centre, an exhibition that brings together female voices from across South India. Working through the medium of printmaking, the artists explore spiritual, emotional, and



Pressed into form

material threads that bind the past and present, tracing how they find form in the future.

"I spent every vacation at my grandmother's home, where she first taught me to draw small rangolis – and over time, the interest grew. What I love about rangolis is how they belong to everyone; it's a shared, collective practice with no sense of ownership. In South India, it's a deeply matrilineal tradition, passed from one generation of women to the next," says Champa, who uses the woodcut technique of printmaking to create her artwork.

Like woodcut, the exhibition also explores myriad techniques of printmaking. Gouri Vemula, uses the drypoint technique, in which she scratches the design directly into the clayboard with a sharp tool. The incised lines that hold the ink give the final print its characteristic blurriness. In her series, the forms appear hybrid – part human, part animal – with a sculptural torso, textured like scales, and a flowing, almost aquatic lower half that unfurls into sweeping, feather-like extensions. "I began noticing how we compare human behaviour with



Tracing time
(Clockwise from far left) Artworks at InKo Centre; Champa Sharath's *Continued Harmony*; and Gouri Vemula's untitled work. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

that these are original works, created by the artist in editions from a single matrix. Because of this lack of awareness, many printmakers move away from the medium to painting. In my research, I have also found that many women artists have stepped away from printmaking, with only a few continuing to engage deeply with the medium," says Lina.

Artist Premalatha Seshadri's work uses etching on zinc plate. The artworks present an interplay of line, texture, and symbolic form, rendered in an earthy palette. Figures and motifs arrive through abstract forms with elongated bodies and mask-like figures.

While most printworks draw on some form of colour, artist Neejina Neelambaran's works have an interesting take; two of her works from the series *Thousand and One Nights* are stripped of colour and reduced to stark contrasts where form, shadow, and silence speak louder than the pigment. "My work tries to transmit the density of our shared baggage into a new liberated dimension," says Neejina.

Together, the exhibition unfolds like inherited stories – layered, incomplete, and continuously evolving.

At InKo Centre, Adyar Club Gate Road, RA Puram till April 18. Entry is free.



Open sesame

Ranked seventh on Asia's 50 Best Bars, Hope & Sesame, brings flavour-forward cocktails to The Flying Elephant for a high energy one-night takeover

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Something exciting is happening to the drinking culture in Chennai. The evolving landscape makes bartenders from around the world curious about what the city has to offer.

One such bar is Guangzhou-based Hope & Sesame, ranked at seven on Asia's 50 Best Bars and at 29

on the World's 50 Best Bars. This weekend the Chinese bar will takeover the bar at Park Hyatt Chennai's The Flying Elephant.

"The drinking culture, as well as the general palate, is quite different from what we are used to in China. The flavours in India feel much more pronounced.



Shake it up (Left) Amy Yu from Hope & Sesame; (inset) The Gentle Irish. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

notes. The standout, however, is the Sha Cha High, a highball-style cocktail with an umami-forward profile.

Ershad Mullick, director, food and beverage, Park Hyatt Chennai, and his team are approaching the takeover as both a showcase and a learning experience. "We do a lot of bar takeovers, domestic and international. It's not just to feature, but to exchange ideas and understand how cocktail trends are evolving," he says, adding that for the evening the chefs at The Flying Elephant have curated six small plates with flavours from the Cantonese and Sichuan cuisines. The team is also helping Hope & Sesame source ingredients for the cocktails.

"We have brought a few key components from Guangzhou, including our homemade shacha bitters, vinegar sauce, coconut oil, and cocoa. These are either difficult to source here or very specific to our recipes," says Amy.

If travelling to China is not on your 2026 bucket list, this takeover is your chance to meet the flavours halfway.

Hope & Sesame will takeover the bar at Park Hyatt Chennai's The Flying Elephant, Guindy on April 5. For reservations, call 8939871128.

Reading the walls

Paintings of Buddha and Jataka Tales inside one of the most ancient Buddhist heritage sites, now explained in a book



Decoding symbols (Far left) The Bodhisattva Padmapani; (left) a stupa at Ajanta; and (inset) Ashwin Prabhu. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Two years ago, author Ashwin Prabhu stepped into Ajanta's dark caves with intention. "I have always had a sense of the fact that this was a spectacular site and held a lot of value. I walked in knowing that I was going to write a book," he says.

The 30 caves are located in the middle of nowhere, a few hours away from Aurangabad in Maharashtra's Sahyadri Hills. His aim was to observe, imbibe, photograph, and note down every detail of the Buddhist murals inside the caves. These were recorded in history books in 1819 by a British officer named John Smith while he was hunting for tigers.

At Ajanta, a Buddhist monument, home to perfectly chiselled viharas, well-constructed stupas, and ornate paintings, dating back almost 2,200 years, one requires a keen eye to take in all the details.

The caves are a repository of some of India's finest ancient art, and home to monasteries, worship-halls and intricate sculptures. Through gestures, colours, and poses alone, one sees a non-linear story, painted by anonymous artists, come alive in darkness. An innate sense of wonder about these rock-cut caves comes alive in Ashwin's latest, *Magnificent Murals - Buddhist Art of*

Ajanta (published by Tulika Books with pictures by Srinivasan Krishnan Rajagopalan). Although a children's book, this text takes time to introduce adults and adolescents alike, to what one might find on a visit to this historical site today.

Did you know that the first four major attempts to record and reproduce the murals at the cave, including that of Buddha's life story, his enlightenment, and the fabled Jataka Tales, all fell victim to various fires? One has no choice but to believe that forces, and perhaps a curse was at play. "It was a chance discovery. When something is set so far back in time, we tend to gloss over why some incidents happened. The chroniclers just said that they had gotten destroyed without getting into the details. Piecing it together meant making connections about the disasters," he says.

A teacher of English and History, Ashwin says that he has always known that there is little space for engagement with his students when there is only one right answer or fact. It is why *Magnificent Murals*, fashioned in an almost field-guide fashion, takes one through not just facts, but space to deliberate.

In the book are vivid pictures of original paintings

in red, brown, white, black, and the occasional resplendent blue, made from lapis lazuli, a precious blue stone imported from Afghanistan and Central Asia, which was once as valuable as gold. Adjacent to the paintings in the book that have suffered intense wear-and-tear and chipping, are line drawings showing us what the paintings may have once looked like. Ashwin hopes to nudge readers in the direction of the historical line of interpretation through the text in the book.

Ashwin says that early endorsements from people like filmmaker-historian Benoy Behl, historian Anirudh Kaniseti and author-naturalist Zai Whitaker, have been encouraging. He is excited to build a bank of books in the same series, he adds. This is his second book, after Ashwin's first book for children, *Sculpted Stones: Mysteries of Mamallapuram* (published by Tulika Books).

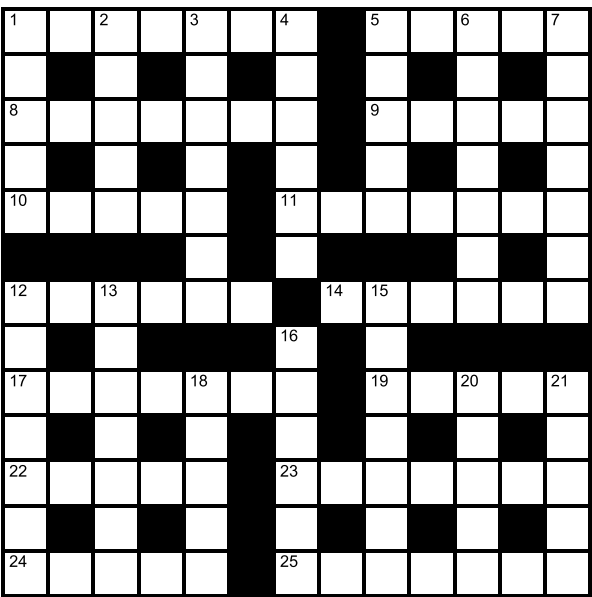
"Can you imagine that there is something many thousand of years old, which still survives? To me, this is fascinating," he says.

Magnificent Murals - Buddhist Art of Ajanta is available on tulikabooks.com



QUICK CROSSWORD #47

(Set by Doppelganger)



Across

- 1 Cast back (7)
- 5 Small fragment (5)
- 8 Type of open-air cinema (5-2)
- 9 Match (5)
- 10 Shaving tool (5)
- 11 5th Greek alphabet (7)
- 12 Partner's family (2-4)
- 14 Knitting pattern (6)
- 17 Synthetic compound (7)
- 19 Open space in forest (5)
- 22 Data (5)
- 23 Instruction (7)
- 24 Relating to waves (5)
- 25 Artists (7)

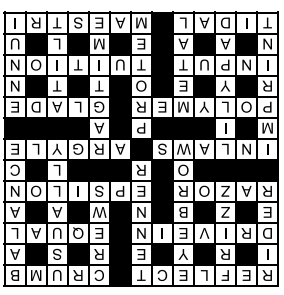
Down

- 1 Clause (5)
- 2 Crisp curls (5)
- 3 Supercilium (7)
- 4 Banknote (6)
- 5 Merchant mariners (5)
- 6 Often (7)
- 7 Remainder (7)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



Solution No. 47





A scrabble meet-up trains beginners to become competitive players

What is the best word to describe people who would like to stay indoors, solving crosswords and Wordles on Sundays? Logfiles? Lexifiles? Word nerds?

Whatever the expression be, a group of 14 people took part in a recent scrabble meet up to discuss their love of words and take part in a competitive version of the game for the first time.

group of 20 and 70, pulled out seven alphabet tiles and got working, hoping to snag points off the double word score.

Litarcade, an organisation that uses games and puzzles to make literature fun, decided that it was time to host a workshop to teach people the nuances of competitive scrabble. In June, they hope to host a scrabble tournament. Training before hand will certainly help, the organisers feel.

Saturday's workshop was led by Ranganathan Chakravarthy, a Chennai-based scrabble grandmaster, coach, and founder of the Madras Scrabble Foundation

(2014). A seasoned player who has represented India at world championships, Ranganathan emphasises that the word game is more than just a pastime. “Playing Scrabble can change your personality – it makes you sharper,” he says. “While many people play it casually, we focus on competitive scrabble here. A crossword is a puzzle, but Scrabble is a game with a defined set of rules.”

Through his work with schools and colleges across the city, Ranganathan trains students in strategy, vocabulary-building, and word formation. While beginners can learn the basics online, he notes that mastering the nuances requires guided practice. “To truly improve, you need a coach,” he adds. According to Jayanthi Somasundaram of Litarcade, the larger goal is to popularise competitive scrabble in Chennai. Their upcoming event is being organised by the Scrabble Association of India from June 26 to 28, and will cater to multiple age groups.

For those looking to get started, the requirements are simple: a copy of the Collins Ultimate Scrabble Dictionary, the Wordchecker app (a tool that checks if a word is valid in the latest official Scrabble dictionary), and consistent practice. "A standard game lasts about 50 minutes and can be played by two to four people," Ranganathan explains.

Litarcade plans to continue hosting meet-ups, providing space and opportunities for players to practise and prepare for the tournament. Participation in these sessions are free to those interested.

To register for training and practice sessions, call 9840124750. For details, madrasscrabblefoundation.org

Lava, the new rooftop restaurant at Taj Club House, offers global comfort food and vantage views



Kefi, the rooftop restaurant at Taj Club House had been synonymous with my post work date nights. When the pandemic hit, this place ceased to exist and eventually, so did my relationships.

But now it has reopened again, this time as Lava. I revisit this old haunt over the weekend with my friend to have a relaxed girl's night out.

When we walk in, the interiors still feel like Kefi with the grey-blue sky above and a 180 degree view of Anna Salai including Spencer Plaza, Taj Connemara, and the LIC building. What is nice is the space does not try too hard. It embraces what it has and

does not rely on bright lights, loud
decor or props.

The menu comprises global comfort food. Hearty soups, sliders, sushi, dim sum, ramen, grills... flavours from the Mediterranean, Europe and Asia. The compact menu for the most part steers clear of haute cuisine and trendy viral dishes, and sticks to food that evokes a sense of comfort, which for sure comes from all the delicious carbs.

Our cocktails are such a contrast. Mine – Strawberry Creme Royale – is a subtly sweet, rum-based drink with fresh cream and strawberry, vanilla pods, and a tinge of cinnamon, while my friend gets a spirit forward picante with fresh coriander, agave syrup and jalapenos which dominate the palate. The drinks and food menu comes alive with textures and flavours on the plate.

The gulab jamun cheesecake seals the deal, as the dessert sits cosily between a layer of French sable cookie and the hearty cheesecake. This is how we finish our meal.

What makes all the difference here is no loud, blaring music. Just gentle peals of laughter and soft murmurs from neighbouring tables. There is something rather soothing and comfortable about the place. For that reason alone, Lava demands a visit.

Meal for two costs ₹3,000 without alcohol. Lava is at Taj Club House, 2 Club House Road, Express Estate, Royapettah.



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The advertisement features two women: Jemimah Rodrigues, a cricketer, on the left holding a cricket bat, and Kayadu Lohar, an actress, on the right posing under studio lights. In the center is a bottle of NXTFACE Shake It Bright - Glow Bi-phase Serum. The background is split vertically, with a night stadium on the left and a dark studio setting on the right.

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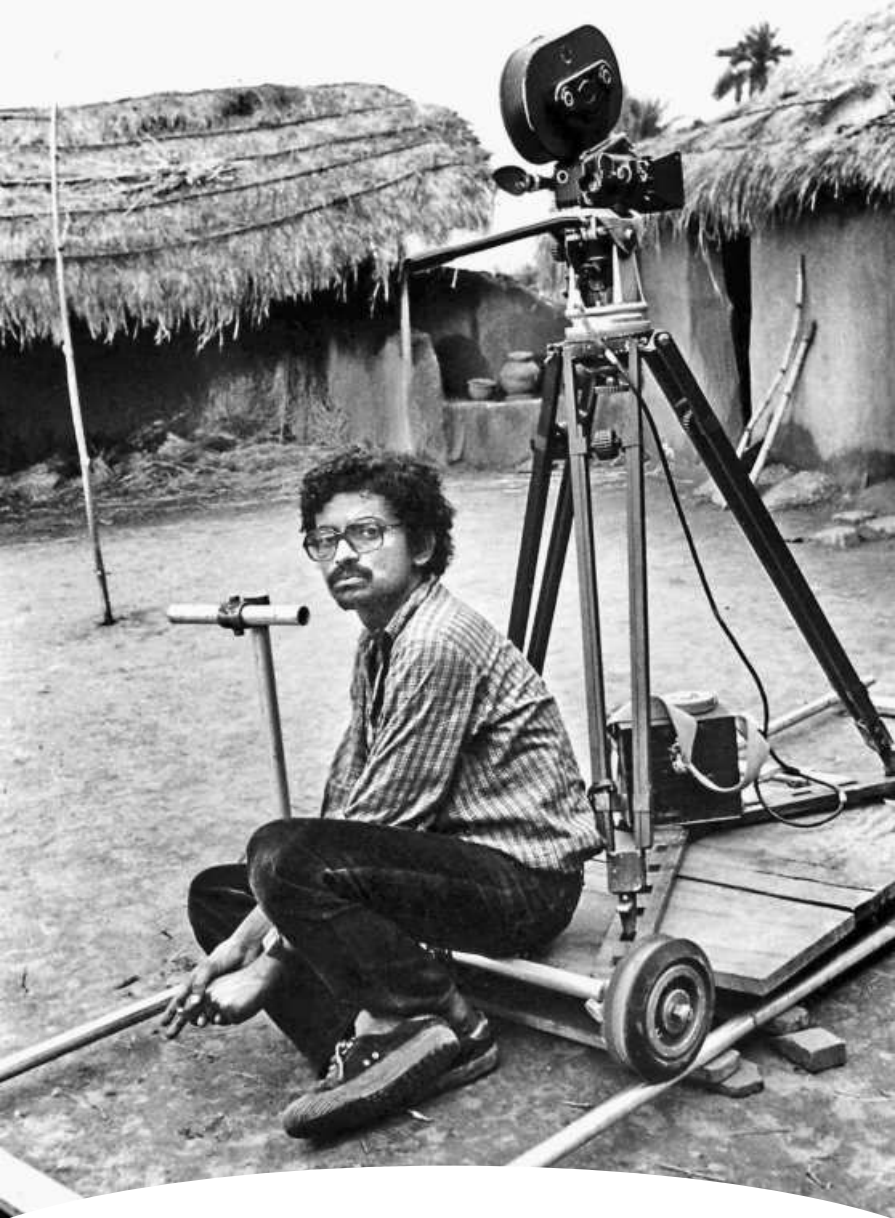
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Nayanthara, Salman join hands
Tamil superstar Nayanthara is all set to star opposite Salman Khan in an upcoming film helmed by Vamshi Paidipally. Backed by Telugu producer Dil Raju, the film will go on floors in April. The news was announced by Raju's Sri Venkateswara Creations on their official social media handles. "It's an honour to have you on board for something truly special that's underway (sic)" wrote the banner. Nayanthara, who made her Hindi film opposite Shah Rukh Khan in *Jawan*, was last seen in the Telugu film *Mana Shankara Vara Prasad Garu*, co-starring Chiranjeevi and Venkatesh. The actor also has *Toxic*, co-starring Yash; *Mookuthi Amman 2*; *Mannangatti Since 1960*; *Hi*, co-starring Kavin, *Rakkayie*; *Patriot*, co-starring Mohanlal and Mammootty; *Dear Students*, headlined by Nivin Pauly; and *Nandamuri Balakrishna's* upcoming Telugu film, among other films in the pipeline. Vamshi is best known for helming Tamil superstar Vijay's 2023 actioner, *Varisu*. He has also made Telugu films like *Brindavanam*, *Yevadu* and *Oopiri* among others.

From Legend to Leader
The 'Legend' is back. After his 2022 film debut, Saravanan – popularly referred to as 'Legend' Saravanan – is back with an action flick titled *Leader* that hits screens on April 3. During its recent audio launch, he said, "The film is about an innocent father and son who live happily, but the entry of a gang changes their lives. It does not have item songs, but it has songs that travel along with the story, with meaningful lyrics." Featuring an ensemble cast including Payal Rajput, Andrea Jeremiah, Lal, Prabhakar, Amritha Iyer and VTV Ganesh, it has been shot across multiple locations, including Thoothukudi, Ooty and Georgia, and has music by Ghibran. *Leader* has been directed by RS Durai Senthilkumar, well known for helming the Dhanush-starrers *Kodi* and *Pattas*.



Archives come alive

Filmmaker and Sheriff of Kolkata,
Goutam Ghose on restoring films and histories

Shreya Banerjee

In Goutam Ghose's *Paar* (1984), the director stages a crossing that is as brutal as it is symbolic – a man and a woman wading through a swelling river, herding pigs to survival. Decades later, Ghose finds himself drawn to a different kind of crossing. One that moves between two cities, two archives, and two kinds of memory. In Kolkata, as Sheriff, he is working to restore fragile colonial-era High Court records. In Chennai, he is trying to salvage his own films, whose negatives are cracking with time. At Prasad Laboratories in Chennai, the past returns through fragmented reels and sound strips that have outlived the systems meant to protect them. "Earlier, producers knew film negatives were lying in



What you should watch

Mrinal Sen's *Bhuvan Shome*, *Calcutta 71*, *Mrigayaa*, *Kharij*
Ritwik Ghatak's *Meghe Dhaka Tara*, *Subarnarekha*, *Titash Ekti Nadir Naam*
Tapan Sinha's *Kabuliwala*, *Jhinder Bandi*, *Hatey Bazarey*, *Ek Doctor Ki Maut*
Satyajit Ray's *Pather Panchali*, *Charulata*, *Jalsaghar*

labs, but no one really cared," Ghose says. The shift from analogue to digital around 2012 only worsened this neglect. Laboratories shut down, climate controls failed, and fragile film stock was left to decay. When Ghose began tracing his own work, he

found both damage and possibility. What was once indifference has turned into a race against time. While films like *Paar* have already been restored, *Antarjali Jatra* (1987) is currently underway, and *Dokhol* (1981) remains a work in progress. Amongst documentaries, the ones on Bismillah Khan (*Sange Meel Se Mulaqat*, 1989) and Satyajit Ray (*Ray*, 1999) have been restored. For now, the effort has been guided as much by survival as by sentiment. Films that could be retrieved in workable condition have taken precedence. Many of these works mark defining moments in Ghose's career, making their recovery

Pages from the past
Gautam Ghose.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

deeply personal. What has changed, Ghose notes, is the ecosystem around these films. OTT platforms are rediscovering older works, creating a renewed appetite for restoration. "What is available online is often of very poor quality". If Chennai is where Ghose restores his cinematic past, Kolkata is where he confronts a different archive. As Sheriff, an office established in 1776, in the early years of the East India Company, his role is largely honorary, but layered with institutional responsibility. It involves public engagements, and a connection to civic bodies, including spaces like the Presidency Jail. More significantly, it has drawn him into an ongoing effort with the Calcutta High Court to preserve centuries-old legal records.

These documents, over 250 years old, are brittle, fading, and at risk of disappearing altogether. "They contain everything from who was tried, who was punished, what decisions were taken," Ghose says. Restoring them is not just an archival exercise, but an act of historical recovery. There is, within these papers, the possibility of revisiting familiar narratives and of looking again at moments like the aftermath of the Battle of Plassey, at the shifting structures of power under colonial rule.

The parallels between the two roles are difficult to ignore. In both, Ghose is working against erasure. Chennai, with its robust film infrastructure, offers a glimpse of what is possible. "When I visited Prasad, I saw a massive restoration unit where so many films are being worked on. That is a very positive sign," he says. It also sharpens a contrast. The Bengali film industry, he points out, struggles with turnover and distribution. Audience habits have shifted.

For Ghose, restoration is not an exercise in nostalgia. It is a way of ensuring continuity by allowing works, both cinematic and historical, to remain part of public life. There is, however, a deeply personal note beneath it all. "If I can see all my films restored during my lifetime, that would give me immense satisfaction," he says.

Between Kolkata and Chennai, between court records and celluloid, Ghose's work circles the same idea that what we inherit is always at risk of being lost. The past, as in *Paar*, lingers like a swollen river, uncertain, difficult to cross, yet refusing erasure, returning slowly and insistently to the light of moving images.

Push of a button

BGIS 2026 ends its nearly three-month long tournament in Chennai, crowning Team iQOO Soul the winner

Kamalika Chatterjee

If you were a gamer, gaming influencer, streamer or a video game enthusiast, you were probably at the fifth edition finale of the Battlegrounds Mobile India Series (BGIS) 2026 in Chennai, where the atmosphere was electric, and so was the audience.

The tournament featured players from beginners to professionals from across India playing Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI) in teams of four. The tournament started with 70,000 teams, with semi-finals and core tournaments, narrowing down its players. With music, fireworks and non-stop energy, the three-day finale was conducted from March 27 to 29 at the Chennai Trade Centre with 16 teams and players from all over India, along with live streaming.

Team iQOO Soul emerged victorious taking home prizes worth ₹1 crore, with Team Genesis Esports and Team Orangutan crowned the runners-up and second runners-up, respectively, bringing an end to the two-and-a-half month-long tournament. The event was conducted by Krafton India, a national gaming organisation.

"Lifting the trophy was emotional, we pushed through with our fans' support, resetting after every match and trusting each other to make it this far," said Nakul Sharma, from Team iQOO Soul.

The growth of esports tournaments has also seen a rise in the fanbase with the increasing viewers and players. With more influencers and streamers promoting gaming as more than just a hobby, it is being seen as a potential growth industry for the makers and players alike.

"The numbers prove that gaming interest is alive, growing, and still in its early stages despite the stigma. We're not just rooting for teams, we're rooting for gaming to become India's next big phenomenon," said Ayush Shukla, an influencer.

With open tournaments that welcome players of all skill level, it encourages the gaming community of India to participate and try out their skills. "Every year, we aim to discover young talent and give them a platform where learning, competition, and opportunity can turn gaming into a real career path," said Karan Pathak, associate director, esports, Krafton India.

"Gaming has real career potential, it takes time, but the opportunities are expanding, and it's exciting to see where it's headed. It is no longer just limited to your phones or devices, but broadening into bigger and more opportunities," said Pradeep Kumar, an attendee of the event.

Tournaments like the Battlegrounds Mobile India Series 2026 underscore how the esports community has moved beyond niche circles, evolving into a dynamic ecosystem.



Game on The grand finale of Battlegrounds Mobile India Series (BGIS) 2026. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Director Abhilash Reddy on blending sport, scale and sentiment in India's first motocross film

Biker revs up



Unexplored terrain
Sharwanand in the film; (right) Abhilash Reddy.
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At the UV Creations office, director Abhilash Reddy pauses mid-rush to talk about his Telugu film *Biker*, touted as India's first motocross film. The team is in the final stretch, optimising it for large-format screens – Dolby Vision, PCX, EPIQ and PXL.

After two seasons of the web series *Loser*, Abhilash directed the 2024 feature film *Maa Nanna Superhero*, and is known to gravitate towards stories rooted in sport and familial ties, particularly father figures. "I grew up playing basketball," he says. "While studying BSc Electronics, I discovered storytelling through short films. My father encouraged me to join Annapurna School of Film and Media." A middle-class upbringing, and witnessing his father's struggles, continues to inform Abhilash's emotional lens. His breakout series *Loser*, which

followed struggling athletes navigating cricket and badminton, brought him industry attention – eventually leading to actor Sharwanand recommending him to UV Creations.

The idea for *Biker* took shape with collaborators MVS Bharadwaj and Shrawan Madala, with whom Abhilash worked earlier for *Loser*. "We had no reference points, there are no mainstream motocross films here, only racing videos on YouTube. But that's what made it exciting."

While Indian cinema has featured high-speed biking, think *Dhoom* or the Tamil film *Valimai*, off-road dirt biking remains largely unexplored.

Coimbatore connect

The story was sparked by an anecdote narrated by Abhilash's motocross racer friend, Vignesh,

from Coimbatore. "It is an incredibly demanding sport – physically and mentally. I began wondering what a rider's emotional headspace looks like, especially when dealing with personal upheavals."

Starring Sharwanand, Malvika Nair and Rajasekhar as the father and coach, *Biker* traces three phases of a rider's life.

Sharwanand underwent a physical transformation for the role. "He was 85-90 kilograms when we began, and worked out to shed weight."

Filming came with a challenge: helmets obscure expression. Abhilash's workaround was to set parts of the film in the 1990s and early 2000s, when half-helmets were common, allowing for visible emotion. The time period also helped showcase the two-stroke bikes and

the transition to four-stroke vehicles.

Shot over 120 days, with over 60 dedicated to biking sequences, the film was largely shot in Indonesia's Kendari and Sumbawa regions.

"We worked with an 80-member crew and hired local riders, while ensuring the terrain matched Coimbatore and Hyderabad for authenticity."

Safety remained paramount. "A bad fall can end a career," says Abhilash. Action choreographer Dhilip Subbarayan, who had worked on *Valimai*, helped design the sequences.

Since the teaser and trailer dropped, comparisons to *Jersey* and even *FI* have surfaced – something Abhilash finds both nerve-wracking and flattering. "I am a huge fan of director Gowtam Tinnanuri and loved how he balanced cricket and the emotional drama in *Jersey*. My film is in a more commercial zone; it has both scale and drama."